

Hand Swelling - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1458 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- UAT-only adult and pediatric hand-swelling pathway screening for infection, allergy, vascular obstruction, constriction and occult trauma before in-person assessment.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [DURATION] How long has the swelling lasted?
2. [YES_NO] Is the skin red, hot, or painful to touch?
3. [YES_NO] Is one hand more swollen than the other?
4. [OPEN_TEXT] What is the age; are rings constricting, is there fever, allergy, wound/bite, line/procedure, pregnancy/postpartum status, neurovascular change, hidden injury or child safeguarding concern?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Motor Vehicle Accident

Did this problem begin with a motor vehicle crash or as part of a multi-system crash injury?

A motor vehicle crash or multi-system crash injury belongs in the Motor Vehicle Accident pathway.

1. Disposition level 70

Is hand swelling severe with a cold/pale/blue/numb hand or constricting ring, or is there rapidly spreading redness/swelling plus marked systemic illness or deterioration?

Inability to stand or bear weight, or marked systemic deterioration including in a child, requires emergency assessment through the Qatar pathway.

1. Disposition level 70

With no emergency feature, is there any persistent or unexplained hand swelling, asymmetry, redness/heat, wound, child concern or higher-risk context?

In-person assessment is required to exclude infection, allergy, vascular/lymphatic obstruction, inflammatory disease and occult trauma.

Advice

Qatar emergency hand-swelling response

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 for an ambulance for rapidly spreading swelling/infection with systemic illness, severe pain, or a cold/pale/blue/numb hand; do not self-drive. Remove rings if easy; do not squeeze or drain. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: fever worsens; redness spreads; colour or sensation changes.

In-person hand-swelling assessment

- Arrange in-person assessment; unexplained swelling may reflect infection, inflammatory disease, allergy, vascular obstruction or occult injury. Medication and exact Qatar destination are local approval required.
- Call Back If: redness, warmth or fever; swelling progresses.

First aid

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 for an ambulance for rapidly spreading swelling/infection with systemic illness, severe pain, or a cold/pale/blue/numb hand; do not self-drive. Remove rings if easy; do not squeeze or drain. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.

References

- NHS.UK, "Joint pain", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/joint-pain/> (page last reviewed 26 February 2026) - applied to hand swelling

Provenance

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